

Davis describes the 19th-century American Temperance (anti-alcohol) movement as an arena that brought immigrant Jews, Germans, and Irish into a kind of conversation with one another and with native-born Protestants. What does this “conversation” tell us about the similarities and differences between these immigrant groups, their relationships with one another, and how they were each viewed by the larger, native-born society?

“Do as We Israelites Do”

*American Jews and the Gilded Age
Temperance Movement*

The ladies who gathered in Cleveland in November 1874 had set themselves an ambitious goal: they were going to establish a national women’s organization that would work toward the total eradication of beverage alcohol from American life. Although both individually and institutionally affiliated with the Protestant church, they hoped that all American women would join their cause—an aspiration that generated a brief debate about the prudence of including the word “Christian” in the organization’s name. One of the women present suggested that by referring so explicitly to their religious affiliation, they risked “shut[ting] out the Jews.” But the majority dismissed this concern, and in the end they declared themselves the Woman’s Christian Temperance Union (WCTU). “Since there was no creed test” for members, they assured themselves, the alienation of Jewish women “need not be feared.”¹

Twenty years later, an editorial in the monthly periodical *American Jewess* suggested that those initial concerns had been well-founded. The 1895 article, likely written by the editor and clubwoman Rosa Sonneschein, reported that at a recent WCTU conference, Frances Willard, the group’s president, urged the organization to create alliances with Jewish and Catholic women. Though this indicated “tolerance and progress,” Sonneschein proclaimed, she predicted that Jews would continue to avoid the organization, as they had done since its inception. That word, it seems, had indeed proved alienating; “the name *Christian*,” she wrote, “indicates too narrow a sphere.”²

Jews’ main objection concerning the WCTU, however, was not its sectarian name but the cause it espoused. Jews consumed alcohol in their weekly home-based religious rituals and in their social gatherings, Sonneschein noted, yet “drunkenness is amongst them . . . only encountered in a few isolated cases.” Alcohol abuse, in other words, was not a Jewish concern, and

how was this view applied to xenophobic religious associations of abstinence?

Jews' moderate drinking habits indicated that the problem with alcohol was not located in the alcohol itself, but in the drinker who failed to exercise self-control. Because of their distinctive cultural relationship to alcohol, she concluded, Jews would forever remain "loath to subscribe to total abstinence" and would never join the ranks of temperance activists.³

American Jews supported moderation as a personal virtue and an admirable trait, and a few encouraged some regulation of alcohol commerce. But throughout the late nineteenth century, Jews generally rejected the anti-alcohol movement. Like Sonneschein, they dismissed the movement's claim that morally right-minded people never touched a drop, and pointed to themselves as proof that alcohol could be consumed in a spirit of self-restraint. Further, they protested that the movement's demand for the legal prohibition of the manufacture and sale of alcohol imposed unjust restrictions on personal behavior and commercial enterprise. And they expressed horror at the gendered nature of temperance politics, insisting that the woman's sphere did not include public demonstrations and acts of civil disobedience. In sum, American Jews regarded the anti-alcohol movement as politically wrong-headed—even repulsive—and certainly as inimical to the civil liberties guaranteed by the Constitution. *we're one of the good ones!*

Jews' presence on the "wet" side of temperance and prohibition debates is not surprising, since the anti-alcohol movement threatened their own ancient religious rituals and contemporary social practices. Considering the prominence of alcohol producers and purveyors in many nineteenth-century Jewish communities, anti-alcohol movements also posed a danger to their entrepreneurial freedom and economic well-being. But Jewish criticism of the temperance movement was an act of communal self-protection with objectives beyond the right to drink and to traffic in commodities of their choosing; it was a defense of the idea of the nonsectarian state, which American Jews held dear. Jews' experience in the United States—where they could participate in economic and political life and join civic institutions to an extent impossible elsewhere—had facilitated the creation of a group identity that was acculturated and American but also unapologetically Jewish. The temperance movement's religious commitments signaled the expansion of nineteenth-century efforts to "Christianize" American life and reorganize its laws around Protestant values and morality. Jews feared that if these movements were successful, their equal status, even their citizenship, could be in peril.⁴

Jews could have responded to the temperance movement merely by disputing its claims to be consistent with American political practices, and by protesting that mandatory abstinence would infringe on all Americans' con-

stitutional rights of conscience and property. That they did, and in doing so they refined their communal position on the relationship between religion and politics in the United States. They also joined other Americans who were skeptical of the temperance movement's call for sumptuary laws by insisting that "prohibition does not prohibit," and pointing out that simply making alcohol illegal would not keep people from finding a drink if they really wanted one. But they went a step further: American Jews presented themselves as a preferable counterpoint to both the drunkard and the teetotaler, and counseled their fellow Americans, as Rabbi Marcus Jastrow said in 1874, to "do as we Israelites do" by neither loving nor despising alcohol excessively. The prohibition debate provided Jews occasion to suggest that their distinctive historical and religious relationship to alcohol made them model citizens whose presence benefited the nation. *Trying to make themselves palatable*

American debates surrounding the effect of alcohol consumption on politics, public health, and morality began well before the American Revolution. Colonists and citizens of the early republic acknowledged the presence of "strong drink" in all aspects of their culture. American and European observers alike expressed amazement and dismay at the ceaseless flow of liquor, in business dealings, at political gatherings, and in the home, where all family members, including women and children, consumed it. "Americans drank at home and abroad, alone and together, at work and at play, in fun and in earnest," the historian W. J. Rorabaugh has written. "They drank from the crack of dawn to the crack of dawn."⁵ Benjamin Rush, the surgeon general of the Continental Army, took issue with the widely held belief that alcohol was an elixir of health, insisting that alcohol created rather than cured illness and inevitably led to physical and spiritual degeneracy. Others claimed that the steady flow of alcohol at civic events (especially elections) and in the military threatened the health of the body politic.

Early temperance advocates urged moderation rather than total abstinence, encouraging their countrymen (and women) to avoid distilled liquors and choose wine, cider, and beer instead.⁶ By the mid-nineteenth century, however, concerns shifted from *what* and *how much* Americans drank to *that* they drank at all. Thousands of temperance societies sprang up all over the nation (and in the Northeast and Midwest in particular) during the 1830s and 1840s, imploring citizens to pledge, formally and publicly, to renounce even moderate consumption of alcohol. Antebellum temperance activism was, in part, a response to the jarring changes wrought by the economic transformations of the day. The nation was growing increasingly urban, industrial, and commercially oriented. Internal migration and immigration from

abroad, which filled cities and towns with newcomers who further upended the traditional social and political order, exacerbating the anxieties provoked by economic change. By swearing off indulgence in alcohol and drunken leisure, teetotalers hoped to master their bewilderment by becoming more productive and manifesting a heightened level of self-control.⁷

What this source of
xenophobia of the times, which
manifested in anti-
temperance

Although they aimed to embody industrial discipline and to control their own passions, in fact their ambitions extended beyond their own personal comportment. Temperance enthusiasts regarded alcohol consumption as a burden on the whole community. If a drinker spent his weekly wages on a payday drinking binge, they pointed out, his family starved. If he drank at work, his productivity (and thus the output of his workplace) suffered. If his alcohol consumption was heavy enough to render him a public nuisance—or worse, a pauper or a criminal—his community was obligated to spend its limited resources on him, and possibly on the family he had failed to support. The common good, some teetotalers insisted, required not only that alcohol be despised, but also that it be out of reach. Antebellum temperance activists most often employed moral suasion and sought to convince drinkers to abstain of their own free will. They regarded coercion, in the form of “no-license” laws and other legislation that limited or prohibited the availability of beverage alcohol, as another possible solution to the nation’s liquor problem. Even as early as the 1850s, exhortations for personal temperance intertwined with demands for total prohibition; the latter philosophy soon dominated.⁸

The religious revivalism of the Second Great Awakening further influenced the growth and direction of the antebellum temperance movement. Protestant revivalists preached that once the nation had collectively abandoned sinful behavior and chosen Christian redemption, the Second Coming of the Messiah would soon be at hand. This marked a shift in American Protestant theology from Calvinist ideas of predestination to the belief that salvation was available to all who chose a righteous path. One achieved salvation via inner piety, and outwardly demonstrated it through church attendance, economic productivity, familial stability and contentment, and participation in the struggle against societal ills like poverty and crime. Not every churchgoing revivalist adhered to the principle of teetotalism; but for those whose zeal for temperance was influenced by millennialism, “ardent spirits” posed a singular danger to the nation’s spiritual health—both individually and collectively, since drinking hardened men’s hearts against both God and their fellow men. In addition to breeding paupers and criminals, temperance Christians insisted, alcohol created a culture of “moderate” drinkers and

alcohol purveyors who could not see the causal relationship between alcohol and poverty—or, worse, were indifferent to it. It was as benevolent and godly to sway a moderate or indifferent drinker to the temperance cause as it was to reform a drunkard.⁹ *So "converting" Jews to abstinence would have been important for this reason?*

Those who defined Christian moral righteousness in total temperance terms, however, were confronted with a problematic text: the Bible. Wine flows through both the Pentateuch and the Gospels. For temperance Christians, the stickiest theological inconsistency was Jesus's consumption of wine during Jewish religious rituals—most famously during the Last Supper, which occurred during Passover and has been described by biblical historians and scholars as a seder, an occasion where wine is copiously consumed. And how would they square the story of the wedding in Cana, where Jesus turned water into wine, with assertions that alcohol was a sinful substance? If the Bible were to be read and understood literally, as they believed it must, the presence of wine in the text would directly contradict the claims and block the goals of the Christian temperance movement.

Some temperance activists conceded that *yayin*, or intoxicating wine, was without a doubt present in the Bible, while pointing out that the ancient Israelites of the Hebrew Bible and the Jews of Roman Palestine lacked sufficient scientific information about the dangers of alcohol. One New York temperance leader suggested in 1839 that if Jesus had had access to the “better knowledge of our times,” he would not have sanctioned the use of wine, much less made it himself.¹⁰ Others, however, sought to do away with the contradiction altogether, by proving that the wine consumed by the early Jews, and therefore by Jesus, was in fact unfermented. Antebellum temperance clergy and lay Protestants pored over the Hebrew Bible in an effort to determine, through exhaustive biblical exegesis, whether the Israelites drank *yayin* or *tirosh* (unfermented grape or raisin juice). If it was just fruit juice, as anti-alcohol absolutists insisted, then there was no wine at the Last Supper. This would mean that unfermented wine, or “new” or “pure” wine as it was also known, could be used for Christian communion; more important, it would buttress temperance Christians' claims that total abstinence was consonant with Jesus's teachings and life.

Thus Jews were brought into early temperance discussions, although primarily as figures of symbolic and historical interest. When possible, evangelical temperance activists sought the expertise of contemporary Jews, under the assumption that current Jewish rituals paralleled those of the biblical era. They found a willing spokesman in the diplomat, playwright, and New York newspaper publisher Mordecai M. Noah. Noah was the best-known Jewish

public figure in the antebellum United States, and his writings, both journalistic and dramaturgic, were widely cited as representations of Jewish opinion and tradition. In 1836, when the secretary of the New York State Temperance Society asked Noah about Jewish wine customs, Noah responded publicly in his newspaper, the *Evening Star*, that Jews commonly used unfermented raisin wine in their Passover rituals. This was true, as we have already seen. But what Noah did not say, and what he probably did not himself know—his knowledge of Jewish law and custom left much to be desired—was that this was primarily a practice of Diasporic expediency, a way for Jews far from Jewish population centers to have access to kosher wine.¹¹

used by Jews to be accepted by Society

For Mordecai Noah, temperance activists' interest in Jewish alcohol consumption presented an opportunity to make a case for Jewish inclusion in American life. When he offered this Jewish practice to Christian solicitors, he intended for Judaism (and Jews) to be regarded as in alignment with a contemporary stream of American morality and politics. But for temperance Christians, Noah's "expertise" was primarily of value because it lent authority to their own theological claims and political demands. In fact, they ignored him when he later pointed to King Solomon's declaration that "wine maketh the heart glad" and criticized the temperance movement's absolutist position.¹² Noah's claims about Passover raisin wine seemed to confirm temperance Christians' theory that Jews did not drink fermented wine at Passover. In the end, that was the only thing his Protestant interlocutors wanted from him.

Noah's failed efforts highlighted a contradiction in Jews' status in the antebellum United States. As a religious minority accorded certain rights, they encountered relatively few barriers to full participation in American life. But according to the majoritarian politics of the nineteenth century, Jews were expected to accept that American culture and common law were Christian at their core. When confronted with attempts to align American legal and social practices with Protestant morality and theology, Jews responded variously. A radical few insisted that only the total separation of church and state could guarantee equality for Jews as a religious minority, and argued that the nation's founding documents guaranteed a high wall between the two. Others took the position that while the Bill of Rights guaranteed tolerance and equality for all peoples of all religions, the United States was still a *religious* (although not a sectarian) nation. Evocations of Christ in political and civic contexts, such as the opening of legislative sessions, were acceptable as long as a reference to Judaism could be included as well.

For much of the nineteenth century, the latter position prevailed. American Jews were usually satisfied when they were able to live as one religious community among many, without molestation or onerous impositions on their consciences or daily practices. When confronted with barriers to full equality and representation under the law, they responded inconsistently, arguing for the right to hold elected office in some cases and capitulating to statutes forbidding commerce on Sundays in others.¹³

But after the Civil War, temperance Christians gathered strength and escalated their demands. They extended their activities deeper into the civic realm, making religious arguments not just for individual abstinence, but also for the total legal prohibition of alcohol commerce. Further, they did so on religious grounds, calling for the overt infusion of Protestant theology into American political life. When Jews responded to this development during the late nineteenth century, they showed far less interest in accommodation than Mordecai Noah's actions had demonstrated. Instead of seeking to establish mutual understanding between themselves and the temperance movement, they openly and consistently denounced its imposition of evangelical morality on American politics.

Rabbi Isaac Mayer Wise led American Jewry in this ideological battle. When Wise founded his weekly newspaper, the *American Israelite*, in 1854, he intended his publication to unify and modernize American Jewry, and to act as armament in defense of Jewish civil liberties.¹⁴ Wise editorialized about local and national political developments, and the temperance movement became one of his regular subjects. He was acerbically critical of temperance activists, expressing pointed irritation toward those who invoked religious ideology in their protests. "If religion and prayer are abused to wage war on liquor to-day," he wrote in 1880, "they may be abused to-morrow, on the same principle precisely, to persecute . . . Freemasons, Catholics, foreigners, infidels, or anyone who . . . does not conform to vulgar prejudices."¹⁵

Wise's accusation that the anti-alcohol movement "abused" religion indicates a shift in American Jewish political rhetoric. Beginning in the 1870s, and with greater force and frequency in the decades to come, rabbis and other Jewish communal leaders denounced erosions in the wall between religion and the state. American Jewish outspokenness was in part inspired by the growth of the American Jewish population itself, which by 1880 numbered approximately 250,000. Immigrant and native-born Jews were generally acculturated, economically stable, and as committed to the health of American institutions as they were to Jewish organizations.

20th century - Jews more resistant to imposition of Protestant culture

Even as Jews as a group achieved both critical mass and middle-class status in the United States, the threat of marginalization (or possibly exclusion) emerged in the form of campaigns for a “Christian America.” The unprecedented devastation of the Civil War led evangelical Christians, and some moderate Christians as well, to conclude that the nation had fallen from God’s grace. Postwar spiritual anxieties were inflamed by many of the same economic and demographic changes that had spurred antebellum revivalism: industrialization, increased poverty and wealth disparity, and the growth of non-Protestant populations in American cities. Protestants from throughout the religious and political spectrum hoped to right the nation’s spiritual wrongs by calling for legislative reform acknowledging Christ’s moral authority over the government and the laws it created. They organized the National Reform Association, which set its sights on a constitutional amendment that would revise the preamble to include recognition of “the lord Jesus Christ as the Ruler among the nations, and His revealed will as of supreme authority.” Others lobbied for the legal enforcement of Sunday Sabbath observation. While Sabbatarians found allies among a wide range of activists—especially labor organizers and workers’ advocates seeking a guaranteed, government-sanctioned day of rest—those who oriented their politics around Protestantism hoped, first and foremost, that Sunday laws would strengthen the nation’s devotion to God.¹⁶

American Jews responded with denunciations of the Christianization of the civic realm. Although there remained areas of Jewish life that some proved willing to compromise—a number of congregations, for instance, changed their Sabbath worship from Saturdays to Sundays in order to conform to mainstream American socioeconomic practices¹⁷—they regarded the imposition of Protestant theology or morality on politics, commerce, education, or the private lives of citizens as a direct threat to the nonsectarian state that guaranteed their equal status.

American Jews, it should be noted, did not contest the temperance movement’s warnings against the dangers of excessive alcohol consumption. “It is undeniable that drunkards are degraded and degenerated persons,” Wise wrote in 1868, “and drunkenness is an evil against which all good men should work.” Rabbi Marcus Jastrow, of Philadelphia’s Rodeph Shalom congregation, spoke of the “human misery” wrought by intemperance. And Gustav Gottheil, rabbi of Temple Emanu-El, the center of Reform Judaism in New York City, called intemperance a “disease” and a “scourge that slays sixty thousand otherwise healthy men and women annually in the country alone and brings ruin to a hundred thousand homes.”¹⁸

Nor did they dispute the claim that American culture seemed to be newly awash in liquor and beer. Wartime military culture had given license to excessive drinking, which the American brewing and distilling industries heartily encouraged. Alcohol trade organizations and lobbying groups (in which Jewish alcohol entrepreneurs often played a role) stood ready to flex their considerable muscle against any legislation that threatened to hinder their business. As alcohol production grew, venues of public drinking proliferated—especially in cities, which were themselves undergoing dramatic growth because of both industrial concentration and immigration from Europe. The number of retail liquor dealers exploded during the late nineteenth century, from fewer than 90,000 in 1865, to 175,000 in 1880, to nearly 200,000 in 1900. These numbers only briefly, in the 1870s, represented an increase in the number of alcohol retailers in proportion to the national population.¹⁹ Nevertheless, anti-alcohol activists shuddered in dismay and horror at the opening of new saloons, and even the creation of new saloon districts, in their cities and towns. They interpreted the sheer prevalence of alcohol and its widespread availability as a sign of social disorder, and regarded it as evidence of politicians' lack of interest in the common good.

American Jews sympathized with concerns that alcohol exacerbated poverty and other societal problems. But those who suggested approval of legislative remedy did so in inexact terms, offering a version of Jewish theological principles that made common cause with Protestant activists' demands for political reform and moral uplift. The 1885 Pittsburgh Platform, American Reform Judaism's founding institutional mission statement, announced Jews' commitment to "the great task of modern times, to solve on the basis of justice and righteousness the problems presented by the contrasts and evils of the present organization of society." These acculturated Jews promised to promote social justice and help the poor—not just the Jewish poor, but the gentile poor as well, who, they frequently pointed out, were most injured by alcohol consumption.²⁰

Most Jews who weighed in on the relationship between alcohol consumption and social problems, however, remained vague about a cure. In the end, they were unwilling to lend their weight to any movement committed to the idea that righteous social reform could emerge only from Christian belief. Cooperation between Jewish institutions and the temperance movement proved impossible, since the movement received guidance and inspiration from evangelical Protestants who insisted that the political, economic, and spiritual state of the nation were inextricably intertwined. The social ills of the day could not be cured without Christ, temperance Christians argued.

So was the
ultimate goal: imposition
of Christianity?

These ideas, and the institutions that promoted them, determined the direction of the postbellum anti-alcohol movement. They also compelled Jews to keep their distance.²¹

Although temperance activists were not uniformly driven by religious faith—and, conversely, not all Christians favored temperance legislation—the movement benefited from preexisting church networks. Through these organizations, both formal and informal, they founded dozens of national, state, and municipal committees with hundreds of thousands of members. Christian institutions, including those comprising non-evangelicals, offered their support. In 1874, both the Seventh-Day Baptists and the National Conference of Unitarians declared themselves to be against all alcohol commerce, and in 1877 the General Council of the Reformed Episcopal Church and the General Assembly of United Presbyterians did the same. They were joined in 1880 by the General Conference of Methodists and by Quaker groups throughout that decade.²²

Temperance organizations ranged widely in their missions, methods, and memberships, but they shared a commitment to the total eradication of alcohol commerce in the United States—by legislative action, ideally. Post-war anti-alcohol activists had reoriented their critique of the national alcohol question away from the issue of the individual drinker. They still promoted individual abstinence, but the movement now regarded the consumer as the victim of a wicked industry. The country's alcohol problem was a systemic problem, they insisted, and the system could be reformed only if the power of government were brought to bear on it. This was a major shift in strategy, credited by the prohibition activist Ernest Cherrington several decades later for “breaking down the ancient doctrine that the temperance movement and political activity should be kept separate,” and ushering in a new (and more efficacious) era of anti-alcohol activism.²³

None of the nineteenth-century efforts to restructure American law according to Protestant morality succeeded at the federal level. But anti-alcohol activists did accumulate significant victories in state legislative battles in the 1880s and 1890s. These achievements included local option laws, which gave counties and municipalities the ability to limit or ban the availability of alcohol by popular vote; taxes and high license fees imposed on producers and purveyors of liquor; and statewide prohibition legislation, although all but three states (Maine, Kansas, and North Dakota) saw these laws overturned by state courts or rejected at the polls by 1900.²⁴

Prohibition legislation was just the sort of imposition of religion on politics that Isaac Mayer Wise abhorred. The movement's victories alluded, in

So these as perfections could be used as a source of force imposed upon Jews?

concrete terms, to the growing activist presence of Protestantism in public life. More worryingly for Wise and his allies, the absolute and unconditional nature of their goal turned the debate over temperance into a zero-sum game, since Jewish religious practices were incompatible with temperance Christians' aspirations. Wise was not merely arguing against legislation that he regarded as ineffectual and unjust: he believed this to be a fight between religious tyrants and defenders of the rights and liberties guaranteed by the Constitution. If the tyrants won, Wise warned, the fundamental rights not only of Jews but also of all American religious minorities could be in danger. Indeed, democracy itself was imperiled. When religious passions of the moment can "override and defy the law and the Constitution," he wrote, "we stand at the brink of lawless despotism."²⁵

Rabbi Marcus Jastrow also criticized the temperance movement on constitutional grounds, and warned against the impact that anti-liquor lobbyists could have on the rights of American citizens. Jastrow and Wise disagreed about much; both men advocated modifications of Jewish practice so that it fit the needs of contemporary American Jews, but Jastrow feared that Wise was moving American Judaism too far from its historical traditions and accused him of draining their religion of its fundamental meaning.²⁶ Wise and Jastrow agreed wholeheartedly, however, on the subject of the temperance movement. Jastrow condemned the temperance movement as "equal to tyrannical pressure," and in a later sermon pointed out the deleterious effects of prohibitory legislation on American property rights. Prohibition of the production and purveyance of alcohol, he insisted, amounted to "confiscation of property and proscription of persons," since hundreds of thousands of working Americans would be driven out of their livelihoods, and millions of dollars of property "reduced almost to worthlessness."

Economic oppression of just this sort, Jastrow insisted, had driven the colonists to proclaim independence from Great Britain's monarchical control. "Beware," he continued. "At some future day that many-headed tyrant may confiscate all your property. . . . This is a question of liberty as against tyranny, a question of the unwritten human rights as against the usurpation of power which assumes the name of right."²⁷ Mandatory temperance laws, for Jastrow, were akin to despotism. In his estimation, the temperance movement sought to enact unconstitutional intrusions of state power that would weaken Americans' fundamental protection from property confiscation by the government.

Jastrow's sermon underscored how debates over the alcohol trade, both before and after the Civil War, articulated wider-ranging concerns over the

nature of American capitalism and the competing demands of individual rights and communal interests in a free market society. Was the alcohol industry to be valued as a force of capitalist dynamism and a source of economic growth? Was its presence in American cities and its popularity among many immigrant groups a benign symptom of cultural diversity? Were its potentially troubling effects on society tolerable and manageable? Anti-alcohol activists declared no, on all counts. When it came to alcohol, these activists insisted, the needs of the community required that the market be strictly regulated. The government was responsible for the morality of the community, and the law should reflect the community's definition of a moral environment. At the very least, they claimed, government should not stand in the way of the majority of voting citizens of a municipality, county, or state if they wished to limit or ban alcohol commerce within its boundaries.²⁸

During the late nineteenth century, American Jews were among those whose disagreement with the anti-alcohol movement included a defense of the constitutional rights of the individual to accumulate and dispense with property as he or she saw fit. Wise and Jastrow evoked the nation's struggle at its founding to throw off England's restrictions on its colonists' civil liberties, which included, in their interpretation, the right to enjoy the fruits of their labor without undue government interference. In doing so, these Jews joined other Americans who extolled the virtues of the free market.²⁹

This was not merely a matter of economic self-interest. Jews' memories of socioeconomic life in central Europe also affected their political and economic ideologies. Jews throughout Europe had long been restricted from owning land and barred from most occupations. Those who had witnessed and benefited from the progressive removal of political disabilities from central European Jewry in the nineteenth century, or who had emigrated to the United States to escape socioeconomic discrimination, regarded economic liberalism and open markets as inextricably intertwined with social and political tolerance. Any possible constrictions of economic and commercial markets—especially when championed by conservative and potentially exclusionary cultural forces—gave Jews cause for concern, as they regarded American socioeconomic environments as more meritocratic than any they had yet encountered. By defending unrestricted markets, which they saw as guaranteed by the liberal philosophies on which the nation was founded, they hoped to protect their own civic interests.³⁰

When American Jews argued against temperance legislation and made their case for limiting the state's role in the marketplace, however, they were also looking beyond their own interests. They insisted that the anti-alcohol

movement sought to undermine the constitutional rights of all Americans. Wise, Jastrow, and other Jewish critics of the postwar temperance movement believed themselves to be defending those prerogatives as Jews and as American citizens. Their Jewish identity, as they understood it, did not isolate them from the broader political culture; rather, it positioned them to defend the Constitution, and the national body as a whole.

These critics also proposed that Jewish particularism benefited the broader national community in their denunciations of the women of the temperance movement. In 1874, Rabbi Jastrow offered a stern rebuke to a group of local women who had asked him to circulate a petition to his female congregants. The petition, addressed to the city's mayor, expressed hope that municipal laws forbidding the sale of alcohol on Sundays would be more strictly enforced. As members of "the sex specially aggrieved by the traffic in alcoholic drinks and the consequent intemperance of husbands, fathers, brothers, and sons," the petitioners begged the mayor to ensure that "the Lord's Day may no longer be desecrated by the traffic in strong drink."³¹

The ladies of Rodeph Shalom were unlikely supporters of the petition, not least because it referred to Sunday as "the Lord's Day." Although a small number of Jewish congregations oriented toward religious reform had switched their Sabbath worship to Sundays or added a Sunday service, Rodeph Shalom had not (though it did adopt other reforms). Even within such congregations, Jewish participants rarely referred to Sunday in traditionally Christian theological terms, or parroted evangelical Protestant demands to ban alcohol commerce (or commerce altogether) on Sundays.

The fact that Jastrow received the petition in early 1874 suggests that its authors were participants in the Women's Crusade, a movement-transforming grassroots direct-action protest against the liquor trade that began in late 1873 and lasted through the following year. Even though women had been an important force in the antebellum temperance movement, they found themselves mostly excluded from formal membership in temperance groups such as the American Temperance Union and the Washingtonians. At best, they were relegated to women's auxiliaries, such as the Martha Washingtonians (also known as the Ladies Washingtonian Society). This marginalization frustrated many temperance women, who insisted that since members of the "gentler sex" were too often at the mercy of drunken men (usually their husbands), denying women the right to fully participate in the movement was not only unjust but also injurious to the cause.³²

In December 1873, middle-class Protestant women in Ohio and western New York State began to orchestrate demonstrations against the Ameri-

can liquor industry. Armed with Bibles and church hymnals, and willing to put their own safety in jeopardy, groups of women preached and sang outside local saloons and liquor stores, stoically withstanding the humiliation—and occasional physical abuse—meted out to them by saloonkeepers and patrons. By the crusade's end in 1874, tens of thousands of women had participated in theatrical displays of civil disobedience in thirty states. They begged and shamed saloon patrons until the men promised never to set foot in a saloon again, and they even convinced some saloonkeepers, liquor dealers, and drugstore owners to destroy the offending stock.³³

There is no record of Jewish women participating in the civil disobedience of the crusade, and considering the overtly Protestant nature of these demonstrations it is unlikely that any did. But some middle-class Jewish women witnessed their Protestant counterparts' engagement in the political sphere, and longed for a similarly bracing outlet through which to express their social and political points of view. They aspired to emulate their gentile neighbors, who organized or joined reform organizations that brought into the public realm what they saw as women's natural, motherly benevolence and single-minded passion for protecting home and family. The National Council of Jewish Women, founded in 1893 by middle-class women of central European birth and heritage, looked to the WCTU as the model for their organizational structure and admired its broad social agenda. And though they never took up the anti-alcohol cause themselves, the *American Jewess's* affectionate and appreciative obituary of Frances Willard in 1898 suggests that acculturated Jewish women held this radical reform activist in high esteem.³⁴

Even if groups like the WCTU sometimes served as models for Jewish organizations, Jewish women hesitated to join reform organizations that were directly affiliated with Protestant church associations. Some Christian social reformers openly sought to bring members into their religious fold, and Jewish women understandably shunned contact with those who expressed missionary objectives. Jewish women thus struggled to find a place for themselves within the larger context of American women's activism. The temperance movement was especially unlikely to attract Jewish women, both because of its open religious affiliations and because few American Jews, male or female, regarded it as relevant to their own experience.

As the Women's Crusade was winding down, Rabbi Jastrow presented his critique of the temperance movement. Among the movement's many repugnant qualities, he announced, was the behavior of the women within it. "There is no division of opinion among us," Jastrow declared, "as to the

impropriety of the ostentatious manner in which those whose province is the domestic altar . . . allow themselves to be dragged into publicity and risk contact with such as ought forever to be excluded from the sight of the priestesses of decency and chastity.” Regardless of their benevolent intentions, Jastrow implied, these women—members of “the sex whose power lies in its weakness”—had overstepped acceptable boundaries. In his estimation, their behavior was fundamentally un-Jewish. “Maybe we are a people too old-fashioned for the ‘woman of the age,’” he quipped. “But it is sure that our hearts shudder at the idea of our wives, mothers, sisters, and daughters” venturing into the political arena and forsaking their dignity.³⁵

Isaac Mayer Wise shared Jastrow’s low opinion of women’s political activism. Wise weighed in on the gender issue in March 1874, a few weeks before Jastrow’s sermon. “Any Jewish lady,” he wrote, “would consider it sacrilege and blasphemy to abuse prayer and benediction for purposes of public demonstrations.” To make his case, he invoked two of the most celebrated women of the Pentateuch: “Miriam shouts and sings when liberty triumphs, Deborah rises when the country is in danger; but there were no whisky Amazons in the tents of Israel. Therefore our daughters cannot be misled into this piece of business.”³⁶

Wise’s term of insult would have been familiar to his contemporaries. Some sympathetic observers evoked the image of the Amazon, the female warrior of Greek mythology, to convey respect and admiration for the movement. Amid the crusade, for instance, the *New York Times* reported that a gathering of “Amazons” in Ohio had “given no rest to the enemy,” the local saloonkeepers. This movement led by “singing ladies,” the *Times* continued, “enlists everywhere the full sympathy of the best people of every town and village . . . [with] a fixed purpose, based upon a principle.”³⁷ According to this view, the bravery of the temperance “Amazons” echoed the fearlessness of their ancient and mythical namesakes.

But Wise did not invest the word with any positive connotations. In his opinion, temperance women radically transgressed their proper role and upended the natural order of gendered behavior—just as the Amazons of ancient myth had. Equally horrifying to Wise, they profaned religion by exploiting it in the service of political ideology. Where others saw noble warriors, Wise saw self-righteous fanatics and obstreperous harridans. Wise used the term as an insult to both their femininity and their politics. He was then able to present an idealized image of the Jewish woman, whom he regarded as the opposite of the temperance crusader: a politically astute yet ladylike, rational, and dignified defender of the nation.

A few weeks after Wise's piece appeared in the *Israelite*, Rabbi Samuel Freudenthal of Williamsport, Pennsylvania, also referred to the women of the temperance movement as "whisky Amazons." In response to yet another missive from a local temperance group (or perhaps the same group that had sent their petition to Rodeph Shalom) "urging him to appoint a committee of six Hebrew ladies to co-operate with it in a crusade," he declared that "it is impossible to fanaticize an Israelite" of any gender. Jewish women, Freudenthal insisted, would not deign to participate in the radical tactics of the Women's Crusade.³⁸ Freudenthal likely had read Wise's editorial in the *Israelite*, agreed with the sentiment, and when the occasion arose, found it useful to borrow his terminology.

As Jastrow's scolding sermon and Wise and Freudenthal's derisive comments suggest, many members of the American rabbinate had decided that temperance activism—and particularly women's temperance activism—had no place in Jewish life. So strong was their conviction, in fact, that they were sometimes willing to stifle the speech of Jewish women who expressed sympathy for the movement. In 1878, when a fourteen-year-old girl named Dora Rosenstein submitted an essay supportive of the temperance cause to Atlanta's *Jewish South*, the newspaper's publisher and editor, Rabbi Edward B. M. Browne, would not let it see the light of day. Browne, who also led the city's Hebrew Benevolent Congregation, noted in his publication that he would have published Dora's "very good" essay "but for the fact that we Israelites need no temperance literature as we are not intemperate. Try something else, Miss Dora."³⁹

Rabbi Wise was correct in asserting that Jewish women would not be found among the "whisky Amazons," as he labeled them, since none engaged in the crusaders' very public form of civil disobedience that he and his colleagues found so repellant. Perhaps some would have expressed sympathy for the cause, if Dora Rosenstein's letter is any indication. We cannot know for sure, because communal leaders who either could not imagine or would not tolerate any Jewish alliance with the prohibition movement were disposed to silence them.⁴⁰ According to most of the Jews who spoke out on the issue of alcohol commerce, the only legitimate Jewish viewpoint was that the anti-alcohol movement's calls for sumptuary legislation were fanatical and intolerant. They insisted on a unified Jewish position on the matter; anything else would undermine their efforts.

Even more to the point, they insisted, sumptuary laws were unnecessary. As proof of prohibition's pointlessness, they pointed directly, and proudly, at themselves, as Rabbi Jastrow did when he chided the crusaders for their claim that women were "aggrieved" by the liquor traffic. "Our women," he

wrote, “are not . . . specially aggrieved by the traffic in alcoholic drinks.”⁴¹ This was a reference to the long-standing assertion made by Jews and gentiles alike, as early as the eighteenth century, that the Jews were a sober and temperate people. The German Enlightenment philosopher Immanuel Kant explained Jews’ aversion to heavy drinking as a reflex of communal self-defense. “Intoxication . . . deprives one of cautiousness,” Kant wrote. Outsiders and marginalized populations who were regarded with suspicion and hostility, such as women and priests as well as Jews, were subjected to “the attention and criticism of the [larger] community and thus cannot relax in their self-control.”⁴²

American commentators also took note of Jews’ reputation for moderate alcohol consumption throughout the late nineteenth century, and even those who viewed Jews in a negative light admitted that Jewish drinking habits were admirably restrained. In 1886, *Life* magazine partly attributed Jewish health and longevity to the fact that Jews “use alcoholic liquors very sparingly and thus keep up good digestion,” even though they were a “holiday-loving people.” Three years later, the temperance publication *Christian Advocate* pointed out, without apparent hostility, that “Jews who drink, but are seldom drunkards, are not as a class in favor of Prohibition.” And in 1892, *Century Magazine* asserted that “the best proof of the moral standing of the Hebrews” was, among other factors, that “drunkenness is not a Jewish vice.”⁴³

In their arguments against prohibition legislation during the late nineteenth century, American Jews regularly highlighted their reputation for sobriety and moderate alcohol consumption, proposing themselves as living proof of the excessiveness of anti-alcohol legislation. They offered Jewish drinking habits as a model for non-Jews to follow, and some even used the inquiries of temperance Christians into the drinking practices of the ancient Israelites to further their case. Isaac Mayer Wise did so with particular vigor, regularly rebuking temperance theologians who tried to harness the Hebrew Bible in support of their cause. He insisted that there was no injunction against alcohol in Jewish history or theology. The leading figures of the Torah all drank fermented wine, he pointed out. Even though some, like Noah, drank to catastrophic excess, Moses “left no law regarding inebriation. . . . The Mosaic code knows of no punishment for the drunkard, not even for the habitual drunkard.” The rabbis of the Talmud went one step further, including wine as a required component of Jewish domestic ritual. Some of them, he wrote, even considered it a sin to abstain from wine.⁴⁴

Wise argued that temperance Christians who hoped to enlist a Jewish Jesus in their battle against alcohol were wasting their time and displaying an

Using model minority role to pre-empt potential harmful imposition

embarrassing ignorance of biblical history. If Christians were going to look to Jewish culture as a model or a guide, he suggested that they dispense with exegetical efforts and instead look to their Jewish neighbors. In 1872, Wise attempted to shift temperance activists' attentions away from the ancient past and toward the present. "Temperance men have often asked us," he wrote, why so few Jews developed excessive and unhealthy habits of alcohol consumption "although scarcely any of them abstain entirely from wine, beer and other fermented liquors." His answer was twofold: from childhood Jews drink alcohol at home, with their parents, as part of their religious ceremonies and learn to respect it; and the very teachings of Judaism created the sort of man who "controls his passions and bridles his appetites [and] has himself, more or less, under the control of reason."⁴⁵

This explanation allowed Wise to make two claims: first, Jews' ability to drink in moderation proved that habitually excessive drinkers should blame themselves and not the substance; and second, American Jews could serve as a model of the rational, self-mastered citizen. When a British doctor and expert on heredity and dipsomania declared that Jews had somehow inherited a physiological insusceptibility to intemperance, Wise countered that it was not "racial" qualities, but rather "the liberated intelligence [which] is the motor of the will to domineer over the lower instincts."⁴⁶ Judaism, for Wise, was synonymous with reason and self-control—crucial traits for the modern and democratic citizenry envisioned by the most optimistic of the nation's founders.

Gustav Gottheil of New York City echoed Wise's arguments. In a sermon on Judaism and temperance delivered in the 1890s, Gottheil also dismissed exegetical claims: "We are sorry we cannot offer the temperance reformer the much-coveted comfort of the example of Jesus," since, as a Jew, he would have consumed fermented wine at the Last Supper. "We may render him more substantial aid . . . not as total abstainers or total prohibitionists, but as a sober people, who have been effectively taught by their religion to use every gift of God and not to abuse it."⁴⁷

The role that the Jewish home and family played in inoculating Jews against excessive attitudes toward alcohol also figured largely in the anti-temperance rhetoric of the Philadelphia rabbi Joseph Krauskopf, a former student of Wise. Krauskopf beseeched American lawmakers to turn away from the temperance movement's demands and instead to look to the Jews, whose thousands of years of experience had led them to a sane and moderate approach to alcohol consumption. "Encourage the method pursued in Israel, a method that has almost freed them from drunkenness and its con-

sequences,” he declared in an 1889 sermon. “Encourage the free and open and unrestricted use of alcoholic stimulants within the sacred environments of the home.” Acceptance of alcohol as a part of everyday life, according to Krauskopf, disinclined Jewish men from running off to the saloon; it kept them at home with their families, and “has contributed no small share to their . . . domestic purity and happiness.” If all would follow the Jewish model, he concluded, “there will be *Temperance with all, Total Abstinence with none*.”⁴⁸ Jastrow, too, counseled his fellow citizens to “raise your children so as not to look with genuine or affected horror on a social gathering that is cheered up with so-called strong drinks, while you see its participants come forth unscathed in body and soul.”⁴⁹ Jews, according to Jastrow, taught every upcoming generation to enjoy both nature’s bounty and the company of others with equal measures of joyfulness and self-restraint.

All these rabbis presented American Jews as exemplars of voluntary moderation, even while they refused to allow Jewish history, or the Jewish body, to be used as weapons in the temperance arsenal. This strategy rendered real, flesh-and-blood Jews, rather than the ancient Jews of the evangelical imagination, as the temperance ideal: sober, industrious, and guided by reason. The Orthodox rabbi J. J. Peres of Memphis took it a step further, claiming that even while Jews drank on occasion (as they are instructed to do by Scripture), they “feel a patriotism too holy to prove themselves bad citizens by indulging in low debauchery.” Love of country, Peres insisted, kept American Jews from drinking to excess and rendering themselves “unworthy of the protection of the laws, the equality of rights, and the love and esteem of their countrymen.”⁵⁰

That Jews regularly partook of drink and yet remained respectable American citizens proved, according to this argument, that total abstinence was unnecessary for a healthy, productive, and patriotic life. This argument also provided an opportunity to advocate for tolerant and unprejudiced political attitudes, and to imply that the nation would be ill served by the temperance movement’s attempts to impose their extremist politics on an increasingly diverse population. Jews implied that they could be the models of such tolerance. Of course, they would also be its beneficiaries. As the New York *Jewish Gazette* editorialized in 1898, “Christian church workers” who advocated temperance “would accomplish more good by teaching the masses to imitate Jewish sobriety, industry, and general good behavior” than they would by legislative means. “As the world is surely progressing,” the *Gazette* continued, “and as fairness and truthfulness are gaining ground, we may expect to have our virtues recognized and valued in the future.”⁵¹

As the short piece in the *American Jewess* suggests, Jewish women also articulated their confidence that Americans might look to Jews as models of moderation in both consumption habits and political values. Esther Ruskay, an essayist on Jewish women's topics for both Jewish and secular publications, explored this issue in a 1902 essay that might have been based on her own experience. Ruskay described a discussion between four American women on some of the political and social movements of the day. Three of these women were Christian, and each was an advocate for a favorite fashionable cause: one a vegetarian, one a suffragist, and the third "a rabid disciple of Frances Willard." The fourth woman, and the only Jew among them, sat silent (and a little bored) until the temperance activist asked, "Is not drinking wines and liquors and stimulants a sin [and] a practice out of consonance with the highest conceptions of manhood?"⁵²

Called on to defend Jewish religious practices, not to mention Jewish masculinity, Ruskay's Jewish character suddenly found her voice. She pointed out that "one of the Psalms refers to God . . . creating wine to make glad the heart of man." Therefore it could not be a sin. Besides, she tells her friends, "wine is a necessary adjunct of [Jewish] ceremonies, and yet intemperance has never been a prevalent vice among Hebrews."⁵³

"As it all came to Number Four in a rush," Ruskay wrote, "she herself was struck by the practical tenor of the laws of her people." Jewish law, she suddenly understood, "enables the Jew to live a temperate, well-ordered life, with none of the evils and none of the fears of this modern age to puzzle or to threaten them." Temperance ladies, according to Ruskay, were so terrified of alcohol's effect on the modern world—so terrified of modernity itself—that they sought to have the substance banished altogether. Jews' moderate relationship with alcohol, on the other hand, proved a saner and infinitely more progressive model of "home protection." Jews, she implied, should be regarded as exemplars of calm rationality in the face of societal change and uncertainty.⁵⁴

Ruskay's story presented Jewish women as uninterested in joining the temperance movement, and "Woman Number Four" offered a sharp corrective to the ideology and practice of the WCTU. Ruskay's critique of anti-alcohol activism reassured middle-class American Jewish men that their wives, sisters, mothers, and daughters did not aspire to enter the political realm, at least not in the style of women's politics most common at the time.

Jewish women's seeming disinterest in the temperance movement also reassured Jewish men that their female counterparts accepted the role of keeper of the home and intergenerational transmitter of Jewish domestic

practices, which included the moderate consumption of alcohol in both social gatherings and religious rituals. That they embraced this role was, in a way, as important as the information transmitted. The possibility that Jewish women might independently follow Jewish men into the public realm, abandon their role as perpetuators of home- and family-based Jewish traditions, and develop social or even romantic relationships with gentiles imperiled the cohesiveness of American Jewish communities. The willingness of women to create and maintain a Jewish environment in the home, and to limit the purview of their organizational activities mainly to within the Jewish community, allowed Jewish men to avail themselves of the relative openness and fluidity of American political, economic, and social life.⁵⁵

The vast majority of middle-class Jewish women eschewed the assertive activist role taken by temperance women, choosing instead the private world of home and insulation within Jewish community. Even so, the stance they took toward alcohol consumption still had significant political meaning. In a culture where middle-class Protestant women were encouraged to ban all alcohol from their homes, Jewish women continued to serve it. They also consumed alcohol as participants in Jewish religious ritual. One illustration accompanying the above-mentioned 1892 articles in *Century Magazine*, captioned “A Jewish Wedding,” depicts a bride poised to take a sip from a goblet of wine. Other illustrations portray Jewish families around a seder table, in a sukkah, and at the havdalah ceremony that ends the Sabbath; in each scene, not only is wine consumed, but it is consumed in the presence of children. For Jewish critics of the Gilded Age temperance movement, this was a point of pride, for it showed Jewish mothers doing their part to create the next generation of temperate, rational, and politically tolerant Americans.⁵⁶

Jews were not the only American ethnic group who were both openly critical of the anti-alcohol movement and happy to point to themselves as exemplars of moderation and rationality. German immigrants, most of whom were religiously moderate Lutheran Protestants, responded similarly. German Americans resented temperance activists’ attempts to restrict American leisure activities, and denounced anti-alcohol activists for encouraging intolerant and antidemocratic impulses in American political culture. As did American Jews, Germans felt that temperance was at its core a battle between those who cherished the liberties guaranteed by the American Constitution and those who hoped to impose puritanical religious beliefs on American civic life.

Anti-alcohol activists had expressed suspicion of European immigrants since the 1830s, when a massive wave of newcomers—more than five million



6. "Feast of Tabernacles," *Century Magazine*, January 1892, 332. A middle-class Jewish family using wine in their celebration of Sukkot. This image challenged prohibitionist claims that alcohol undermined family stability.

men, women, and children, primarily from Ireland and German-speaking central Europe—swept onto American shores. These immigrants arrived with the very same drinking practices and attitudes toward alcohol that temperance advocates were determined to expel from American culture. From the perspective of those whose teetotalism was informed by anti-immigrant feeling, alcohol was a problem imposed on American society by alien and uncontrollable others. Of course, Americans had been drinking to excess well before the 1830s; it might be said that colonial settlers from the British Isles, from the seventeenth century onward, had pioneered European drinking habits in the New World. But temperance nativists either ignored or failed to recognize this continuity between “old” and “new” immigration. Instead, they displaced their anxieties about alcohol onto immigrants, accusing them of degrading American society with foreign habits. Alliances between the temperance movement and the anti-immigrant, anti-Catholic American Party, or “Know Nothing Party,” in the 1850s testify to their shared concerns.⁵⁷

Irish immigrants gave the temperance movement especial unease. Stereotypes of the drunken Irishman, a stock character of anti-Irish propaganda in both the United States and England, intensified nativist fears that Roman Catholics, such as nearly all Irish immigrants were after 1830, could never be made into republican citizens. “King Alcohol,” temperance nativists insisted, was as ruthless a tyrant as the pope, and the Irish immigrant had declared his primary loyalties to both; such a man would only degrade and destroy democratic institutions.⁵⁸ *Temperance WRT Irish was anti-immigrant but also anti-Catholic*

German immigrants had also acquired a reputation for enthusiastic alcohol consumption, but they were not stereotyped as dissolute bingers like the Irish. The image of German immigrants in the native-born mind was shaped by economic circumstances; as a group, Germans achieved middle-class status in the United States more quickly than the Irish did. Germans were regarded as law-abiding and fiscally responsible, and as inheritors of a culture that had produced some of the most enlightened political and philosophical theories and vibrant, progressive arts of the time. Their devotion to beer halls, however, and the ubiquity of Germans in the alcohol trade, led native-born Protestant temperance advocates to view Germans as corruptible and un-republican, and as responsible for a loosening of public morals.⁵⁹ *Jews sold & involved were not*

German immigrants and temperance reformers disagreed vigorously on the matter of Sunday leisure habits. As was the custom back home, German families in American cities enjoyed spending Sundays at the local beer garden, playing cards, discussing politics, and listening to the local German band play music from the old country. German Lutherans saw no sin in

Jews viewed as bibl: cal. models, Germans as hardworking & law-abiding, Irish as poor drunkards

same w/ Jews

moderate alcohol consumption, so why would the Lord's Day be blemished by a glass of beer? But in the eyes of those who thought the day was most properly spent in contemplative worship and prayer, drinking (even in moderation) and card playing on the Sabbath was an impropriety of the highest order. Advocates of Sabbatarian laws aspired to put an end to "Continental Sunday" by outlawing all Sunday commerce, which they hoped would compel Christians to attend church instead.

German Americans regarded attempts to inhibit their leisure practices as fanatical and coercive, and as a threat to their civil liberties. They sensed nativism in the movement's occasional screeds against immigrants, and feared that the anti-alcohol initiative was, at its core, an attack on German culture and German American communities. They resisted temperance legislation via the ballot box, and editorialized against anyone who threatened to curtail the right to drink. "We are no defender of intemperateness," insisted a German American newspaper in Milwaukee, "but we hold fast to the basic principle that every person is independent and should be responsible for his own actions, and that those who arbitrarily transgress the laws of nature and damage their own bodies should alone bear the consequences." Naturally, the German American press, with few exceptions, stood against the women's suffrage movement and women's involvement in politics at any level. Temperance "witches" not only emasculated their fathers and husbands and dishonored their families, they insisted, but, if granted the franchise, could potentially tip the electoral balance toward prohibition.⁶⁰

As did Jews

As Jewish women were also silenced

Clearly, American Jews and German Americans posited remarkably similar arguments against the temperance movement. This does not mean that all these Jewish immigrants thought of themselves as ethnically German, or that German gentiles regarded them as such. The degree to which central European Jews had been acculturated or legally emancipated in their homelands varied widely before German unification in 1871. Relations between Jewish and non-Jewish German immigrants in the United States also varied. The two groups generally enjoyed mutual admiration and cooperation, and even occasionally interacted in informal social settings where alcohol would be present, such as beer gardens, music halls, and private social clubs. But they more often than not remained separate, maintaining their own institutions and residential enclaves.⁶¹

But they did agree that prohibitory laws contradicted American values of liberty and individualism. Both groups expressed impatience with suggestions that drinking in moderation was deleterious, and both willingly pointed to themselves as examples that the opposite was true. Jews and Ger-

mans also shared the opinion that temperance women's political activism was unseemly. Some central European Jewish immigrants also expressed unease, and sometimes even downright hostility, toward the movement for women's suffrage; one Cincinnati claimed that the German Jews of her city had steered clear of the suffrage movement because "they were afraid women would vote [for] prohibition."⁶²

Shared antipathy to the anti-alcohol movement provided an opportunity for Jews to align themselves with German Americans, if they were so inclined. This connection would have served central European Jewish immigrants in three ways. First, it reflected positively on Jews to be associated with German Americans, who were regarded as among the more dynamic, organized, politically engaged, and well-respected immigrant groups in the United States. Second, it allowed Jews a feeling of inclusion and acceptance among non-Jews, an experience denied to all but a few elite of their background in Europe. And third, identifying with German Americans enabled those Jews who were ambivalent about assimilation to embrace a version of American identity that, while acculturated, remained distinct from the rest of American society.⁶³

Although Jewish and gentile immigrants from central Europe generally stood shoulder to shoulder on this issue, their political activism often moved along parallel tracks, utilizing much of the same rhetoric in different settings and venues. One notable American Jewish figure did make an effort to align the two groups in their common efforts. The Bavaria-born lawyer Simon Wolf was a spokesman for both German and Jewish causes. He served on the executive committees of B'nai B'rith and the Union of America Hebrew Congregations, where he advocated for Jewish rights in the United States and abroad. He also worked as a lobbyist for the National German-American Alliance in the early twentieth century. Wolf fought against the anti-alcohol movement throughout his political career, often referring to both his Jewish and German heritages.⁶⁴

One of Wolf's earliest forays into temperance politics coincided with the end of Ulysses S. Grant's presidential administration, in which he held a minor bureaucratic position. Grant's term in office had been marred by corruption and scandal—including a conspiracy between distillers and Internal Revenue officers to defraud the government of liquor taxes, a scheme that came to be known as the "Whiskey Ring." Hoping to keep his job through the next administration, Wolf wrote a letter to Rutherford B. Hayes, the Republican Party's candidate for the 1876 election. He advised Hayes that German American newspapers "charge you with being a strict temperance man,"

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and that this would hurt Hayes with ethnic German voters. He stumped for Hayes as well, traveling to New York City to meet with more than a thousand potential supporters, whom he described as “merchants [and] bankers . . . mostly Israelites and Germans.” Unfortunately for Wolf, Lucy Hayes, the candidate’s wife, was an admirer of the Women’s Crusade. Once in office, President Hayes asked Wolf for his resignation, a move Wolf suspected was the direct result of the first lady’s pro-temperance politics.⁶⁵

Several years after the Women’s Crusade ended, the WCTU founder and former president Annie Wittenmyer published her *History of the Woman’s Temperance Crusade*, an account of the uprisings that sparked the postbellum temperance movement. Wittenmyer’s description of an especially stirring moment of anti-saloon direct action in Newark, Ohio—“a hand-to-hand fight with the powers of darkness”—ended with a pronouncement that good triumphed over evil that day. “The struggle was too intense to last long,” she declared, “but victory turned on Israel’s side, and many saloons were closed.”⁶⁶ Of course, she was not evoking the ancient nation in the same way that Rabbi Wise had when he excluded “whisky Amazons” from their ranks. For Wittenmyer, the whisky Amazons were Israel. Throughout her book, she used language consistent with supersessionist claims that Christians had replaced Jews as God’s chosen, and with temperance evangelicals’ quest to eradicate sin and act as instruments of a divine plan for world redemption. Wittenmyer’s reference to Israel’s victory was, in fact, a triumphalist claim for temperance Christians.

Wittenmyer did mention a few actual Jewish people in her chronicle of the Crusade’s advances. She scornfully described “a Jew’s saloon” in Cleveland, where, presumably in an effort to unsettle the pious ladies, “a picture of Christ . . . was held up on a pole before the crowd, who [*sic*] were drinking beer and blaspheming.” Yet she expressed appreciation for a Jewish saloonkeeper in Granville, Ohio, who “would not, on ‘account of his religion,’ allow the ladies to come into his saloon to pray,” but nevertheless placed carpet and chairs out on the sidewalk so that the women could protest his establishment in some comfort.⁶⁷ Wittenmyer expressed both open-mindedness and ambivalence toward Jews, judged them depending on their behavior, and seemed to have no preconceived notion about their economic relationship to the alcohol trade. Several decades later, the hatchet-wielding prohibitionist Carry Nation—whose violent attacks on saloons in 1900/1901 gained her and her cause much notoriety—spoke of Jews with a mix of admiration and disdain. Despite her distaste for them as economic actors—“I know by expe-

rience that the Jews are tricksters," she wrote in her autobiography—the piety of Orthodox Jews prompted her to treat them with deference. When kosher-keeping Jewish peddlers stayed at the hotel she kept before she was a full-time prohibition activist, she recalled, "my other guests would often regard them with almost scorn, but when they were at their meals I would wait on them myself, showing them this preference, for I could not but respect their sacrifice for the sake of their religion."⁶⁸

These prohibitionists' respect for Jews, however ambivalent, was not reciprocated, even in qualified terms. American Jews were at no loss for reasons to be hostile to Gilded Age anti-alcohol agitators. The movement's goals clashed with Jews' understanding of the United States as a nonsectarian, tolerant, multiethnic nation. Its most powerful and popular organization, the WCTU, was discordant with Jewish ideas of proper gendered behavior. And its success not only would have inhibited Jewish religious practices, but would also have forced scores of Jewish entrepreneurs to abandon a trade that had served American Jewish communities quite well.

To what extent was American Jews' anti-prohibition stance directly influenced by Jewish involvement in the American alcohol trade? While no record of communication between Jewish clergymen and Jewish alcohol producers specifically on the topic of temperance exists, rabbinic leaders' anti-prohibition stances were strengthened by their connections to congregants and supporters who made their living in the alcohol industry. Many of the institutions founded by Isaac Mayer Wise benefited from the generosity and cultural status of Jewish alcohol entrepreneurs. As mentioned above, the Louisville whiskey distiller Isaac Wolfe Bernheim funded the construction of the original library at Hebrew Union College, an edifice that today houses the American Jewish Archives and still bears his name. Members of Cincinnati's Freiberg family, along with other Jewish alcohol businessmen, played important lay roles in the organizations Wise created to unify American Jews and to standardize their religious practices. The mere fact that Wise lived and worked in Cincinnati, and that a significant number of his congregants were in the business, surely heightened his antipathy toward the prohibition movement.

Jewish disdain for the late nineteenth-century prohibition movement, then, was partly motivated by economic self-interest. To dismiss their stance as motivated *only* by economic self-interest, however, fails to take into account American Jewry's wider range of concerns about the implications of the growing prohibition movement. There was little to attract most post-bellum American Jews to the "dry" side of the wet/dry debate. The impor-

tance of the alcohol trade in Jewish life contributed to the development of Jews' anti-temperance politics. But Jews' relationship to alcohol consumption and production, which predated the temperance movement by centuries, was far more determinative, as was their fear that prohibition legislation would lead to further incursions of Protestant religious dogma into the civic realm. Any contemporary political development that might jeopardize Jews' civil liberties—as manifest by the possibility that politics, commerce, or other aspects of secular society would come under the control of sectarian religious forces—was a development of great concern, and, according to late nineteenth-century American Jews, one worth fighting against.